

September

19

1783

Balloon experiment

A sheep, a rooster, and a duck took to the skies in the first hot-air balloon flight to carry living things. Launched by French aviators Joseph and Jacques Montgolfier, the balloon floated in the air for about eight minutes before landing safely.



Also on this day

1893 A new electoral act was signed into law in New Zealand, making it the first country in the world to allow women voting rights for parliamentary elections.

1940 Polish officer Witold Pilecki allowed himself to be captured and held at Auschwitz concentration camp to uncover information about the conditions inside.

1991 The frozen body of a prehistoric human, now called Ötzi the Iceman, was discovered in the Ötztal Alps.

1946

Council of Europe

Following World War II, Winston Churchill gave a speech in Zurich, Switzerland, calling for Europe to unite. It set off a series of events that, in 1949, led to the formation of a council to promote unity, democracy, and human rights throughout the continent.



Born this day

1965 Sunita Williams, US astronaut. On her first two missions, she spent 322 days in space and made seven spacewalks.

Unlikely winner

Despite being the lowest-ranked swimmer at the Sydney Olympics, Eric Moussambani of Equatorial Guinea won his qualifying event for the 100 m freestyle when his fellow competitors were disqualified for false starts.

2000

